Board 1
North Deals
None Vul

	♠ K 7 5 2 ♥ 6 4 ♦ A 8 3 ♣ A K 6 4	
♠ Q 10 4 ♥ J 9 8 ♦ Q J 4 ♣ J 10 7 2	N W E S	♠ J 6 ♥ Q 10 5 3 ♦ K 10 7 2 ♣ Q 9 5
	♠ A 9 8 3 ♥ A K 7 2 ♦ 9 6 5 ♣ 8 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♣	Pass	1♥
Pass	1♠	Pass	3♠
Pass	4♠		
All Pass			

4♠ by North
Lead: ♦2

South would play 4♠.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♦2. West plays ♦J.

North plays 4♠. East leads the ♦2. West plays ♦J.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 2 : ♣ 2 : Total = 5

Counting losers from the North hand you have 2 ♣ losers to get rid of. If you had counted from the South hand there would have been 2 ♥ losers to get rid of. In any case the plan is the same.

Win the ♦A and play ♠A and ♠K. If the ♠s split 3-2 you are home-free. Leave the master trump out and play your ♣ A K and dummy's ♥ A K. Then cross-ruff ♣s and ♥s. Whichever defender holds the last trump is welcome to ruff with it at any time. The defense is also welcome to take their 2 ♦s at any time. Your 10 tricks are safe.

This is another example of the general principle to leave a master trump out.

South and North were able to make all their small trumps individually.

If West ruffs the fourth ♥ with his master ♠Q North just discards a ♦ loser and makes an overtrick.

There is an excellent bidding guideline which tells you how to respond with two 4-card Majors. You bid them "up-the-line". That means you bid 1♥.

Partner's rebid is 1♠.

This hand shows why responder should bid "up-the-line". Partner can now show a 4-card ♠ suit at the 1-level. Imagine the suits reversed - you first respond with 1♠. If partner wanted to show a ♥ suit he would have to go to the 2-level, and he might not have the strength to do so.

Back to the actual situation. Over partner's 1♠ bid you jump to 3♠. This jump shows about 11-12 points and good ♠ support (4 cards). In case you thought this showed 13 or more points that wouldn't be logical. If you had 13 points and 4 ♠s you would jump all the way to game. So 3♠ is invitational. Partner accepts the invitation.

Board 2
East Deals
None Vul

♠ J 4
♥ 6 5 3
♦ J 4
♣ A K 9 6 5 2

♠ K 6 5 2
♥ Q J 10 2
♦ Q 7 3
♣ Q 8

♠ Q 10 7
♥ 9 8 4
♦ K 10 5 2
♣ J 10 3

♠ A 9 8 3
♥ A K 7
♦ A 9 8 6
♣ 7 4

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1NT
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by South
Lead: ♥Q

You have 15 points and you have a balanced distribution. You should open 1NT. It is true that you do not have ♣s stopped, but you are not required to have a stopper in all the suits to open 1NT. Partner jumps to 3NT and you pass.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

South plays 3NT. West leads the ♥Q.

Winner count: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 2 : Total = 6

In many Notrump hands it is good to hold up to disrupt the defender's communications. In this hand you have a double-stopper in ♥s but only a single stop in ♠s and ♦s so win the first trick.

You need 3 more tricks from the ♣ suit. As long as the ♣s split 3-2, which is very likely, you can set up the tricks you need. **BUT**, if you just play ♣A ♣K and then a small one you'll be sorry. Those extra three ♣s will be established as winners but you will have no entry to them.

Instead, you play your ♣4 to the second trick and also play a low card from dummy. This is called Ducking the trick. East/West will certainly win that trick, but you are in control. You can win whatever suit they play and you still have that ♣7 to reach dummy's solid ♣s.

You can see that with ♣s splitting 3-2 the Duck insures the contract.

But just imagine you had played ♣A, ♣K, ♣2. At that point ♣ 9 6 5 would all be winners, but don't think East is going to let you reach dummy with either of those two Jacks!

Board 3
West Deals
E-W Vul

	♠ 9 ♥ A 9 3 ♦ K 5 2 ♣ K J 10 9 6 2	
♠ J 8 6 3 2 ♥ Q 10 8 4 ♦ 9 8 3 ♣ A	N W E S	♠ A Q 10 5 ♥ J 7 6 2 ♦ Q J 10 7 ♣ 5
	♠ K 7 4 ♥ K 5 ♦ A 6 4 ♣ Q 8 7 4 3	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
Pass	1♣	Pass	3♣
Pass	5♣		
All Pass			

5♣ by North
Lead: ♦Q

Is there any doubt? Although you only have 11 HCP your 6-card suit adds 2 more. And with 13 points you should always open. So you open 1♣.

Partner responds 3♣.

With the ♣ fit your hand is now revalued to 15 points. But it's still a close thing. You may be able to make 5♣ or you may not.

Passing would not be horrible - but when in doubt it is usually better to be bold. You cross your fingers and bid 5♣.

North plays 5♣. East leads the ♦Q.

North plays 5♣. East leads the ♦Q.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 0 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

The two black Aces aren't going away so if you are to make this contract you must do something about your ♦ loser. And the only likely place to put it is on dummy's ♠K. If East has the ♠A, you can lead up to the ♠K and make a winner out of it.

Suppose you win the ♦Q in dummy and play a ♣. Somebody will win the ♣A and play another ♦. You win this and lead toward the ♠K. No good. East jumps up with his ♠A and sets you with a ♦ winner.

The problem was that when you played a trump you let the timing go to the defense. They could knock out your last ♦ stopper while they still had the ♠A. Try it this way.

Win the ♦ in your hand and immediately play the ♠9. If East doesn't take his ♠A he'll never get it, so assume he goes up. Now he leads ♦J but you win, get to dummy with the ♥K and play the ♠K, discarding the ♦ loser.

Pulling trumps is very important, but sometimes there is something you must do **BEFORE** you play trumps.

In this hand that something is to establish the ♠K so you can discard your ♦ loser.

Board 4
East Deals
None Vul

	♠ Q J 5 ♥ J 8 7 3 ♦ Q 7 4 ♣ K Q 10	
♠ 10 9 8 7 ♥ A ♦ 10 6 5 ♣ J 9 5 4 2	N W E S	♠ K 4 2 ♥ 5 2 ♦ 9 8 3 2 ♣ A 7 6 3
	♠ A 6 3 ♥ K Q 10 9 6 4 ♦ A K J ♣ 8	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
		Pass	1♥
Pass	3♥	Pass	4NT[1]
Pass	5♣[2]	Pass	5♥
All Pass			

1. Blackwood
2. 0 or 4 aces

5♥ by South
Lead: ♠10

You have a very good hand. But not good enough to open 2♣, so you open 1♥.

Partner jumps to 3♥.

This is close. Partner has 11 or 12 points and good ♥ support. Your hand revalues to 21 points. You might have a slam. You decide to try for it and bid 4NT. Partner replies 5♣ showing no Aces. So much for the slam. You bid 5♥.

South plays 5♥. West leads the ♠10. You put on dummy's ♠J, East plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.

South plays 5♥. West leads the ♠T. You put on dummy's ♠J, East plays the ♠K and you win the ♠A.

Losers: ♠ 1 : ♥ 1 : ♦ 0 : ♣ 1 : Total = 3

You cannot avoid losing either of the two Aces. So therefore you must do something about the ♠ loser. And the only thing you can do with it is to discard it on one of dummy's ♣s.

Be careful. If you lead a trump now a defender will take the Ace and play another ♠, exposing your loser while the ♣A is still out. You must set up the ♣ first. So at trick 2 play your ♣ to dummy's ♣Q. A defender may win this and play a ♠, but you win the ♠Q and play the ♣K, discarding your ♠ loser. Now you switch to trumps.

The way you decide whether to start pulling trumps right away is to use your imagination.

Imagine what the defense will do if you lead a round of trumps. Then imagine what they will do if you play a different suit instead.

Board 5
North Deals
N-S Vul

	♠ Q J 7 4 ♥ A K ♦ 10 8 6 2 ♣ A K Q	
♠ K 10 9 8 ♥ 9 6 3 ♦ Q J 4 ♣ 9 7 2		♠ 5 2 ♥ Q J 10 8 4 ♦ K 9 ♣ J 8 6 3
	♠ A 6 3 ♥ 7 5 2 ♦ A 7 5 3 ♣ 10 5 4	

West	*North*	*East*	*South*
	1♦	Pass	2♦
Pass	3NT		
All Pass			

3NT by North
Lead: ♥Q

With 19 points you are too strong to open 1NT so you open 1♦. Partner responds 2♦.

Perhaps you can make 5♦. But 9 tricks are easier than 11 so you bid 3NT. Notice that there was no reason to "show" your ♠ suit. If partner held 4 ♠s he would not have bid 2♦.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

North plays 3NT. East leads the ♥Q.

Winners: ♠ 1 : ♥ 2 : ♦ 1 : ♣ 3 : Total = 7

You can create one winner in ♦s if they split 3-2, but too late, the defense would have set up their ♥s. So you must get 2 more ♠ tricks.

This is one of the most misplayed positions in bridge. The usual approach is to lead the ♠Q, hoping that East holds the ♠K. But this can't succeed. If East does hold the ♠K he will cover, either this trick or the ♠J, and someone's ♠10 will become a winner. Of course if West has the ♠K then the finesse will fail, along with your chance of 2 more winners.

The correct way to play for 2 more tricks is to hope **WEST** has the ♠K and lead twice toward your ♠ Q J. So win the first trick, play ♠4 to dummy's ♠A. Lead the ♠3 toward your hand, playing the ♠J if West plays low. (Of course if West ever plays the ♠K he gives you two winners immediately.) When the ♠J wins, return to dummy with the ♦A and lead the ♠6 toward your ♠Q.

When West holds the ♠K you can always get 3 ♠ tricks if you play correctly.